ADAPTIVE HUMAN–AI COLLABORATION IN CUSTOMER-FACING B2B WORK

By: Madhura S
25F227

AGENDA

1. Research Topic and Study Context
2. Sample Details
3. On-Ground Reality During Interviews
4. Interview Details
5. Analysis and Findings
6. Learning and Managerial Implications

RESEARCH CONTEXT

Study Focus

This study explores how AI is used in customer-facing B2B roles and how it shapes work, customer interaction, and employee judgment.

Areas of Focus:

- Factors driving AI use in B2B roles
- Changes in work practices and customer interactions
- Situations where AI helps or falls short

Approach

Qualitative, interview-based research with customer-facing B2B employees across professional service contexts.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

RQ1: What factors have influenced how you use AI in your role?

RQ2: How has using AI changed the way you work and interact with customers?

RQ3: In what situations has AI been most helpful, and in what situations has it been most risky or less effective for you?

SAMPLE DETAILS

Respondent 1:

- Role: Audit Assistant
- Industry: BFSI
- Age: 24 | Gender: Male
- Experience: 21 months

Respondent 2:

- Role: Business Development Associate
- Industry: Asset Management / Financial Services
- Age: 26 | Gender: Male
- Experience: 2 years, 5 months

INTERVIEW DETAILS & ONGROUND REALITY

Interview Details:

• 2 in-depth online interviews, 20–30 minutes each
• Semi-structured format with follow-up on AI use, work, customer interaction, and risks
• Audio-recorded and transcribed for thematic coding

On-Ground Reality:

- One initially selected respondent from the paper manufacturing industry (20–30 years of experience) reported no use of AI in daily work, making the interview unsuitable for the study.
- The respondent was replaced with an AI-active customer-facing professional to maintain consistency with the research focus.

KEY FINDINGS: RQ1 & RQ2

Factors Influencing AI Use (RQ1)

- Work-level: task complexity, urgency, time pressure, and skill gaps drive AI adoption.
- Organizational: manager support, AI availability, performance expectations shape usage.
- Individual: open mindset, prompt engineering skills, learning orientation, and prior experience.

How AI Changed Work & Interactions (RQ2)

- Faster task execution, improved output quality, and better documentation.
- Enhanced customer preparation, strategic support, and stronger presentations.
- Increased employee confidence and improved decision support in client-facing situations.

Human-AI Collaborative Roles

- **AI handles:** information retrieval, drafting, data analysis, problem solving, and decision support.
- **Humans provide:** contextual understanding, professional judgment, critical thinking, refinement, and customer relationship management.

Key Insights

AI improves productivity; human expertise remains central for final decisions.

KEY FINDINGS: RQ3

AI is most helpful for

- Technical tasks requiring structured output and documentation
- Operational and time-sensitive tasks under deadline pressure
- Drafting, summarising, and formatting structured work
- Background research and pre-interaction preparation
- Data analysis and decision support in well-defined contexts

AI is risky for

- Creative thinking and open-ended problem solving
- Understanding nuanced human behaviour and emotion
- Complex professional judgment in ambiguous situations
- Tasks prone to hallucinations or numerical inaccuracies
- Situations requiring contextual or relational sensitivity

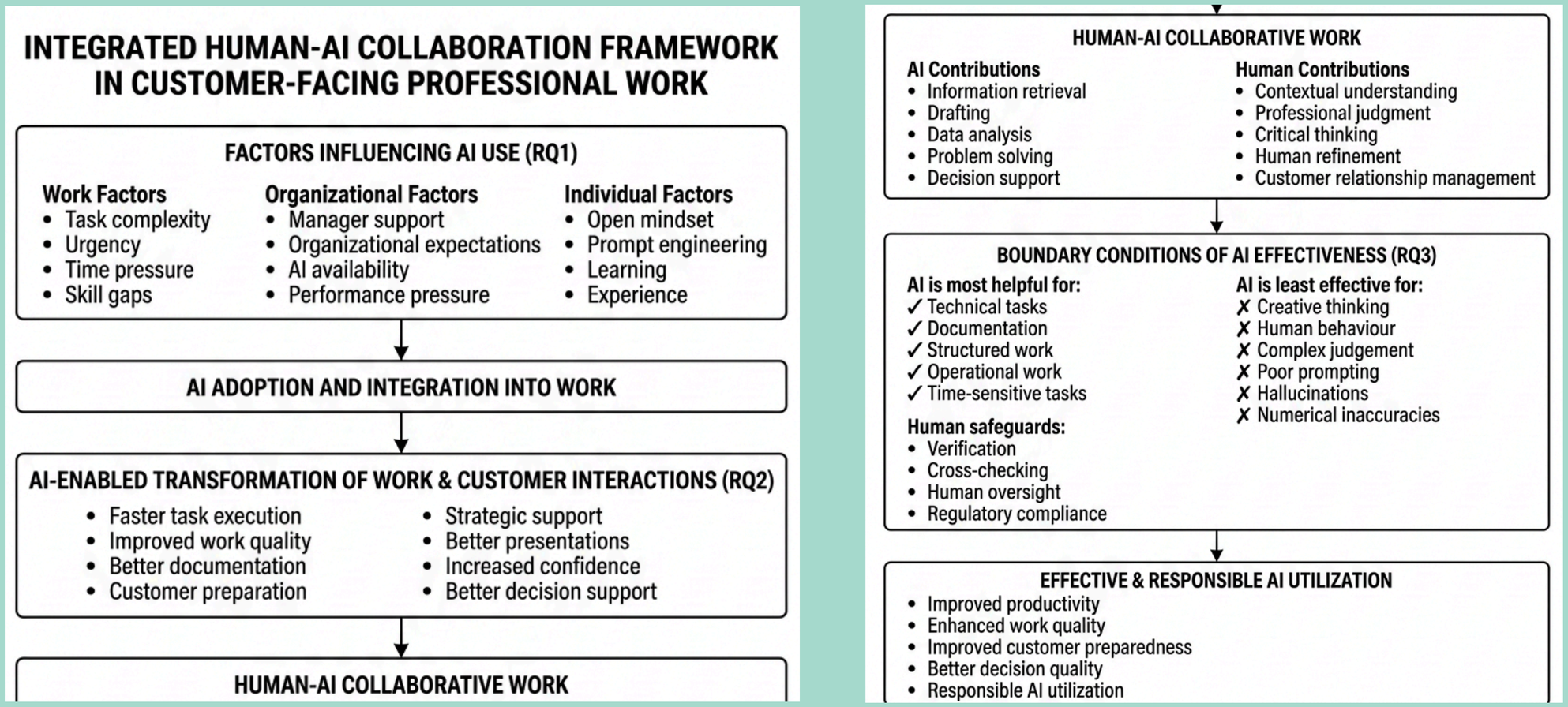
Human safeguards

- Verification and cross-checking of all AI outputs
- Human oversight to ensure regulatory compliance
- Professional judgment applied before client delivery

Key Insights

AI must be used carefully with consistent human oversight to manage inherent risks and limitations in customer-facing B2B contexts

INTEGRATED CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK



LEARNING & PEOPLE IN SERVICES MARKETING

- AI is an assistive tool, not a replacement for frontline employees — human judgment, contextual understanding, and professional expertise remain central to effective customer-facing B2B work.
- Customer trust and professional credibility remain critical in B2B services; managers and employees actively shape how AI is adopted, integrated, and governed within their roles.
- Human refinement is essential for all customer-facing outputs — AI enhances productivity and preparedness, but final decisions and relationship management require human oversight and responsibility.

Q&A